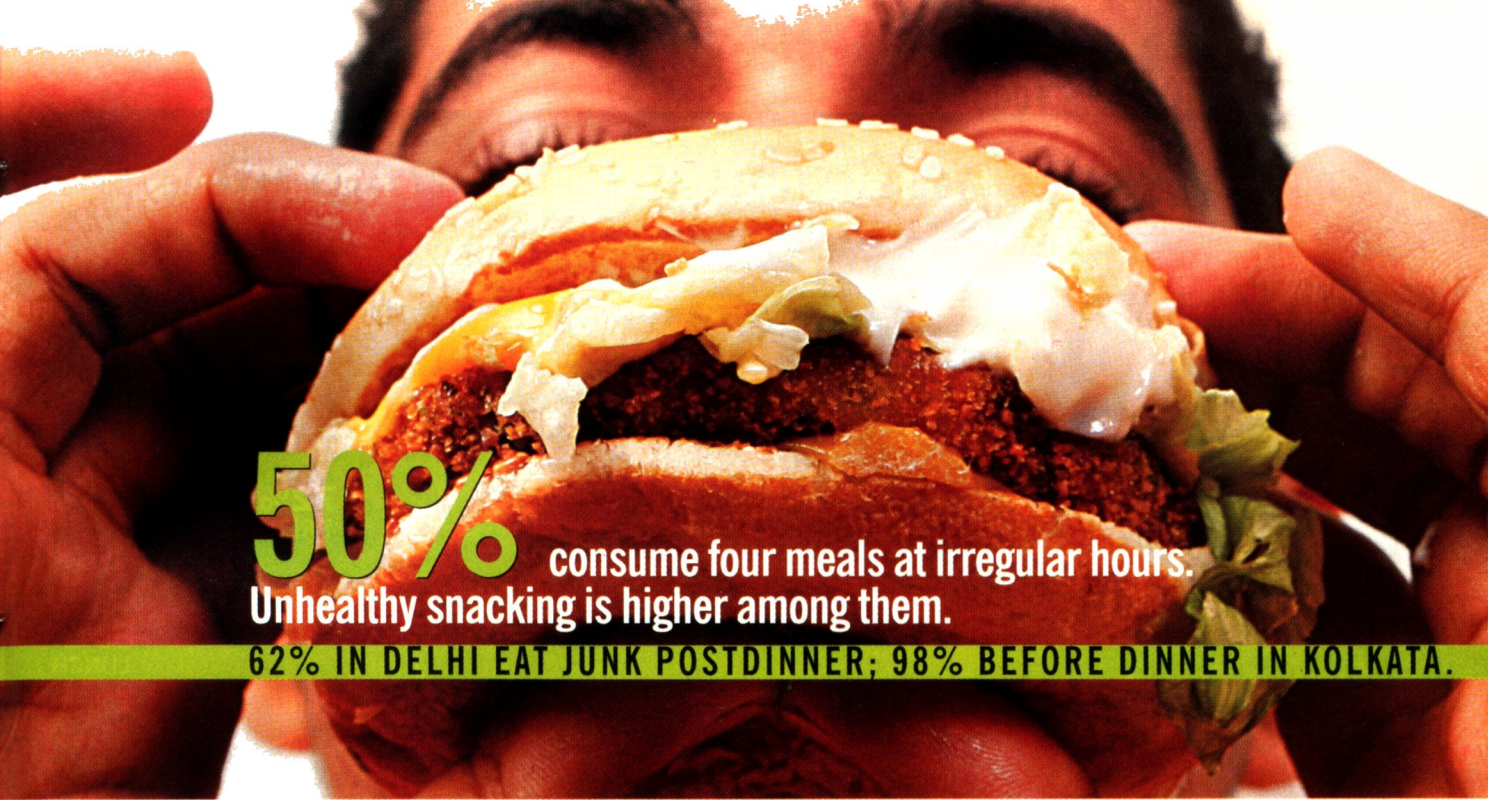




50% consume four meals at irregular hours.
Unhealthy snacking is higher among them.

62% IN DELHI EAT JUNK POSTDINNER; 98% BEFORE DINNER IN KOLKATA.

problem gets kicked into overdrive during the diet-danger months of the party-happy holidays.

Much of that seems to be happening in over-fed, urban India. When do we stop eating? In 24 hours, minus eight hours of sleep time on average, urban Indians gorge on food every two hours, shows the survey. Of all the regular meals, breakfast is a serious affair in every metro. But within two hours, 70 per cent in Delhi, 61 per cent in Chennai and 50 per cent in Mumbai start munching midmorning snacks (Bangalore and Kolkata are not too keen on this). Delhi again tops in teatime bites (80 per cent), followed by Chennai (74). Kolkata leads in predinner nibblings (98 per cent), followed by Chennai (77). Delhi needs its postdinner sweets and beverages (62 per cent) more than any other metro just before nodding off at night.

Our relationship with food grows even more warped, as constant eating blurs the divide between healthy-unhealthy food. Consider this: although

breakfast is one of the most healthy meals for us, 75 per cent eat unhealthily—with endless cups of tea and coffee and biscuits. For midmorning snacks, 51 per cent consume more tea, coffee and biscuits; 73 per cent wolf down unhealthy combinations of tea, coffee, biscuits, muri and namkeen (Bangalore takes the cake at 99 per cent). Predinner snacking tops the chart with 90 per cent eating unhealthily across metros. Kolkata shows the way with 99 per cent gorging on deep-fried pakoras, samosas, kachoris, noodles, biscuits and chips. Bangalore throws up a close challenge (95 per cent), followed by Delhi (89). Dinner is more wholesome, with postdinner gluttony by 32 per cent of the population.

At the heart of this food mania, fruits are battling it out with biscuits. On the face of it, fruits win: 73 per cent believe fruits to be “ideal for kids”; 72 per cent think “they are nutritious”; 63 per cent know they are “easy to digest”; 56 per cent hold that they “can be eaten anytime” and 54 per cent find them “ideal between the meals”. On the contrary, biscuits are “not that easy to digest” (62 per cent); “can’t be eaten anytime” (54 per cent); “not good enough for eating when not hungry” (52 per cent). Then why are all the in-between munch-hours filled up with biscuits? The only count where biscuits win hands-down over fruits is availability: 98 per cent claim biscuits are “very easily available”.

The bottomline is: the easier food is to grab—even if the difference can be measured in seconds—the more you will eat. For the fast pace of modern life puts convenience before everything else. Across metros, 62 per cent mention unhealthy, convenient food as “ideal snacks”, while 51 per cent cite healthy foods. For over half the respondents noodles and pasta are “light yet filling,” “convenient” and “quick to prepare;” If for 18 per cent, sandwiches, toasts

LOADING UP ON JUNK

If Kolkata is the chips capital, Bangalore tops in noodles and Chennai in biscuits.

